Later Start Times Are Worth Trying: The Case for Starting High School Later

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Few school decisions are as simple to describe and as hard to carry out as the time of the first bell. Moving it later changes bus routes, budgets, and family schedules, so districts want good evidence before they act. The evidence in the three studies reviewed here is limited, but it points one way. High schools should start later in the morning, because a later bell raises attendance, shows no sign of hurting test scores, and carries a real but manageable transportation cost.

Attendance Improves, Especially for Older Students

The strongest reason to move the bell is that more students show up. Rivera (2021) followed 4,200 students in one district and found that after the first bell moved 45 minutes later, attendance rose from 91.4% to 93.5%, a gain of 2.1 percentage points. A student who is absent cannot be taught, so attendance is where every other benefit begins.

The gain was not spread evenly. Rivera (2021) reported that attendance rose by 3.0 points among students in grades 11 and 12. A change that helps the oldest students most is aimed at the right group.

Test Scores Did Not Suffer

Critics of a later bell often fear a trade-off: students may sleep more but learn less if the school day shifts. The available evidence does not support that fear. Chen and Okoye (2022) studied 3,900 students and found that in the first year after a later start, test scores did not change significantly. The mean difference was 0.4 points on a 100-point scale ($p = .62$). In plain terms, any difference this small is well within what chance alone could produce.

This result should be read carefully. It does not show that later starts raise scores, and the authors themselves say that longer follow-up is needed (Chen & Okoye, 2022). Still, the finding matters for the argument. A district weighing a schedule change is mostly worried about harm, and the first-year data show none. Combined with the attendance gains, the picture is of a policy that helps students show up without costing them on tests. If later data reveal an effect, either good or bad, districts can adjust, which is a reason to start collecting that data, not a reason to wait.

The Cost Is Real but Manageable

The honest objection to later start times is money. Brooks (2023) sampled 15 districts that moved to later starts and found that 11 of them needed an extra bus tier. Transportation costs rose by an average of 6.2% of the transportation budget. A district that ignores this will be surprised by it, and some budgets are tight enough that a 6.2% increase is a serious problem.

But the numbers also put the cost in proportion. The increase is a share of the transportation budget, not of the whole school budget, and it is an average across districts, so some paid more and some paid less. Four of the 15 districts did not need an extra tier at all (Brooks, 2023). The right response is planning rather than refusal: districts can study their own routes before committing, budget for the likely increase, and weigh it against the attendance benefit. A cost that can be estimated in advance is a cost that can be managed.

Weighing the Evidence

Taken together, the sources describe a trade that favors the change. Attendance rises, and rises most for juniors and seniors (Rivera, 2021). Test scores show no significant change in the first year (Chen & Okoye, 2022). Transportation costs go up, but by a measurable amount that most districts can plan for (Brooks, 2023). It is also worth being clear about what this evidence cannot say. Each attendance and test-score study followed students in a single district, and the test-score finding covers only one year. These limits call for care in how the change is rolled out, not for abandoning it.

Conclusion

High schools should start later in the morning. The attendance gains are measurable, the first-year test results show no harm, and the main cost, extra buses, can be estimated and budgeted. Districts should move the bell, plan for transportation in advance, and keep tracking test scores over several years so that the longer follow-up Chen and Okoye (2022) call for actually happens. A change with clear benefits, no detected harm, and a known price is a reasonable one to make.

References

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Chen, L., & Okoye, A. (2022). Start times and test scores in one district. *Journal of Fictional Education, 14*(1), 12-30.

Rivera, M. (2021). Later start times and attendance. *Journal of Fictional Education, 12*(3), 44-58.